

Economic History II

Rulers and the performance of states

FGV EPGE

Outline of the class

- The question: did national leaders change the fate of their countries?
- **Ottinger and Voigtländer (2025)**: the ability of European monarchs and the performance of their states.
- Dube and Harish (2020): queens, kings and participation in war.
- Same setting for both: European monarchies, where the ruler was fixed by birth.

An old question

- Can a national leader change the fortunes of a country?
- One camp: history is made by exceptional individuals.
- The other camp: structural demographic and economic forces determine both the fate of a state and the leaders it throws up.
- Debated in the social sciences for more than two centuries, and still open.

Two sides

- Carlyle (1841): “history of the world is but the biography of great men”.
- Braudel: “Men do not make history, rather it is history above all that makes men.”
- Tolstoy called leaders **history's slaves**: “every act of theirs is predestined from eternity”.
- Engels: with no Napoleon, someone else would have filled the place.

Why the question is hard to settle

- Napoleon is the identification problem in one man.
- Born to a modest family on a Mediterranean island, far from the centers of power, and he still reached the top.
- So: did he shape events, or did the circumstances produce a Napoleon?
- Leaders are not assigned at random, and reverse causality runs the other way: strong states make famous leaders.

What economists brought

- Jones and Olken (2005): leaders who die in office by accident or natural death, an event outside politics, are followed by changes in growth.
- Besley, Montalvo and Reynal-Querol: sudden departures of educated leaders cut growth most.
- Two gaps remain. Leader **quality** is never observed, only inferred from growth around the death.
- And the timing of the exit is exogenous, but the choice of the successor is not.

The setting the authors want

- Ideal experiment: a sequence of randomly appointed leaders, with observed and varying ability, governing over a long horizon.
- Unattainable, but European monarchies from about 1000 to 1800 come close.
- **Hereditary succession**: the next ruler is predetermined, independent of ability.
- Ability varies for a reason unrelated to politics: centuries of inbreeding among the dynasties.

Monarchs and states

Ottinger and Voigtländer (2025), *History's Masters: The Effect of European Monarchs on State Performance*

HISTORY'S MASTERS THE EFFECT OF EUROPEAN MONARCHS ON STATE PERFORMANCE

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We create a novel reign-level data set for European monarchs, covering all major European states between the 10th and 18th centuries. We first document a strong positive relationship between rulers' cognitive ability and state performance. To address endogeneity issues, we exploit the facts that (i) rulers were appointed according to hereditary succession, independent of their ability, and (ii) the widespread inbreeding among the ruling dynasties of Europe led over centuries to quasirandom variation in ruler ability. We code the degree of blood relationship between the parents of rulers, which also reflects "hidden" layers of inbreeding from previous generations. The coefficient of inbreeding is a strong predictor of ruler ability, and the corresponding instrumental variable results imply that ruler ability had a sizeable effect on the performance of states and their borders. This supports the view that "leaders made history," shaping the European map until its consolidation into nation states. We also show that rulers mattered only where their power was largely unconstrained. In reigns where parliaments checked the power of monarchs, ruler ability no longer affected their state's performance.

KEYWORDS: Leaders, state performance, institutions.

"It was a time ... 'when the destinies of nations were tied to bloodlines'."
– Robert Bartlett ("Blood Royal: Dynastic Politics in Medieval Europe," 2020, p. 432)

Dynastic rule and hereditary succession

- Most European monarchs came to power under fixed rules of succession.
- Usually **primogeniture**: the eldest living offspring inherits, typically the eldest living male.
- Common on the Iberian peninsula early, then England in 1066 and France in 1222.
- It displaced succession by siblings and election of rulers by feudal elites.
- Dynasties therefore lasted: every king of France until 1789 descended from Hugh Capet, who ruled 987 to 996.

Intermarriage among dynasties

- Marriage between ruling houses was routine. The Spanish and Austrian Habsburgs married cousins over multiple generations.
- The Church restricted cousin marriage, but the rule was rarely enforced on monarchs: the pope granted **dispensations**.
- Intermarriage among royal dynasties actually rose over the early modern period, helped by Protestantism dropping the ban.
- The original restrictions had nothing to do with health: they aimed at weakening closed kinship networks.

Inbreeding and capability

- The more genetically related the parents, the higher the risk of recessive gene disorders in the offspring.
- Children of first cousins: about five times the risk of intellectual disability, and lower cognitive ability on average.
- **Cognitive ability** is, in turn, a documented attribute of successful leaders.
- So the chain runs: more inbreeding, less able ruler, and from there to the state.

Nobody involved knew

- The correct way to measure inbreeding was only developed in 1921.
- Consanguinity in a pedigree was read as a positive feature, signaling a clean royal bloodline.
- As late as 1927 Malinowski could write that “biologists are in agreement that there is no detrimental effect produced upon the species by incestuous unions”.
- Woods, the source of the ability data, believed the opposite of what the paper finds: “From their intermarriage with their own kind, in connection with the force of heredity, we find an explanation for their relative superiority”.

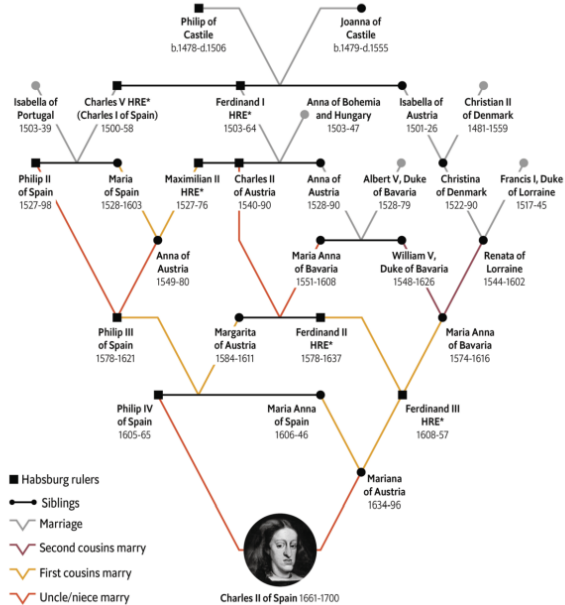
A tale of two Carloses

- Spain illustrates the variation the paper uses: **within the same state, over time.**
- Carlos II, King of Spain 1665 to 1700, at the end of a line of marriages between Spanish and Austrian Habsburgs.
- Carlos III, from 1759, with very little accumulated consanguinity.
- Same country, same institutions, opposite outcomes.

Carlos II

- Coefficient of inbreeding 25.36, as high as for children of siblings, although his parents were uncle and niece (12.5).
- The rest was **hidden** in the deeper layers of the pedigree, from repeated cousin and uncle-niece marriages in earlier generations.
- He started talking at age 4 and walking at 8. He became king at 4, and his mother Mariana ruled as regent until he turned 18.
- Hamilton on his personal rule: “incapable not only of governing personally but of either selecting his ministers or maintaining them in power”.
- He died without an heir, ending the Spanish Habsburg dynasty.

The ancestry of Charles II of Spain



Reading the pedigree

- All four of Carlos II's grandparents descend from Joanna and Philip I of Castile.
- Orange and red lines: first cousins marrying, uncle and niece marrying, repeatedly.
- The visible part of his inbreeding, 12.5, comes from his parents alone.
- The other half is invisible from the marriage contract, and was invisible to the family too.

Woods on the two Carloses

— **Charles II**
An imbecile. Virtues negative.
a; *G* 284-317.

1679-1700 —
Misery, poverty, hunger, disorders, decline, especially in agriculture, finances, and strength of the army. *a*; *A* v, 277; *B* xvii, 136-7, 170, 186-7, 234, 402-412, 426; *H* xi, 379, 381, 451, 485-6; *J* ii, 158.

+ **Charles III**
Enlightened, efficient, just, and sincere. Not brilliant, but had a very well-balanced mind. *a*; *G* 392-411.

1759-1788 +
Continued improvement in financial and commercial conditions, including agriculture and the useful arts. Efficiency of the army raised. Foreign policy not particularly successful. *A* v, 170, 171, 175, 181, 283, 284; *B* xx, 360-80; *H* xiii, chap. III, 210-224.

Carlos III

- The Bourbons took the Spanish throne after the succession war, which broke the closed Habsburg circuit of kin marriage.
- Carlos III inherited in 1759 from his **half-brother** Ferdinand VI, who left no heirs.
- His parents were only third-degree cousins, and the hidden component was small too: inbreeding of 3.9, against 9.55 for Ferdinand VI.
- Woods: “enlightened, efficient, just, and sincere. Not brilliant, but had a very well-balanced mind”.
- Payne: “probably the most successful European ruler of his generation”.

Woods on two English reigns

+ **Henry VIII**

Extraordinary vigour of mind and inflexibility of will. Accomplished and versatile, but imperious, selfish, cruel, and sensual. *a*; *c*; *O* ii, 462.

1509–1547 +

Greatly increased importance of England internationally. Growth of agriculture, grazing, commerce, manufactures and navy. Greater influence over Wales and Ireland. Constitutional decline. *b*; *M* 260; *O* ii, 462.

+ **Elizabeth**

Extremely able, scheming, practical, and brave. Vain, luxurious, wilful, mendacious, and vindictive. Patriotic and unusually popular. *a*; *b*; *c*; *A* 733–748.

1558–1603 +

Peace, prosperity, progress. Political prestige vastly increased. Growth in wool manufactures, but greater growth in commerce. *b*; *A* 744, 745, 778, 780, 785, 789.

The data

Frederick Adams Woods

- Woods (1873 to 1939), lecturer in biology at MIT, interested in the heredity of mental and moral qualities.
- He turned to European royal families because their pedigrees, letters and court biographies are documented over many generations.
- In 1906 he graded hundreds of members of noble families; in 1913 he added a coding of **state performance**.
- He was a proponent of Social Darwinism. His hypothesis, that kin marriage among successful dynasties produced better rulers, cuts against the paper's finding.

Ruler ability

- Woods graded intellect only: moral traits were deliberately left out of the classification.
- A “+” for high cognitive ability, a “-” for incapable, an intermediate mark for the rest.
- Each ruler gets a short written justification and references, as in the Carlos II and Carlos III entries.
- The paper calls this variable **ruler ability** throughout.

State performance

- Woods coded, on the same three-point scale, how the state did during each reign.
- Dimensions: finances, army, navy, commerce, agriculture, manufacture, public building, territorial changes, “condition of law and order, general condition of the people as a whole”, political liberty and diplomatic prestige.
- Deliberately excluded: literary, educational, scientific and artistic activity.
- Example: Maria Theresa of Austria, 1740 to 1780, “able and very industrious”, under whom “industry, commerce, and agriculture improved”.

The sample

- Woods records **366 reigns**, from Hugh Capet in France to Paul of Russia, who reigned until 1801.
- 13 states: Castile, Aragon (Spain), Portugal, France, Austria, England, Scotland, Holland, Denmark, Sweden, Prussia, Russia and Turkey.
- Ability and state performance are both available for 339 reigns.
- Of those rulers: 128 clearly incapable, 123 clearly capable, 88 neither. Of the reigns: 104 clearly bad, 143 clearly good, 92 neither.

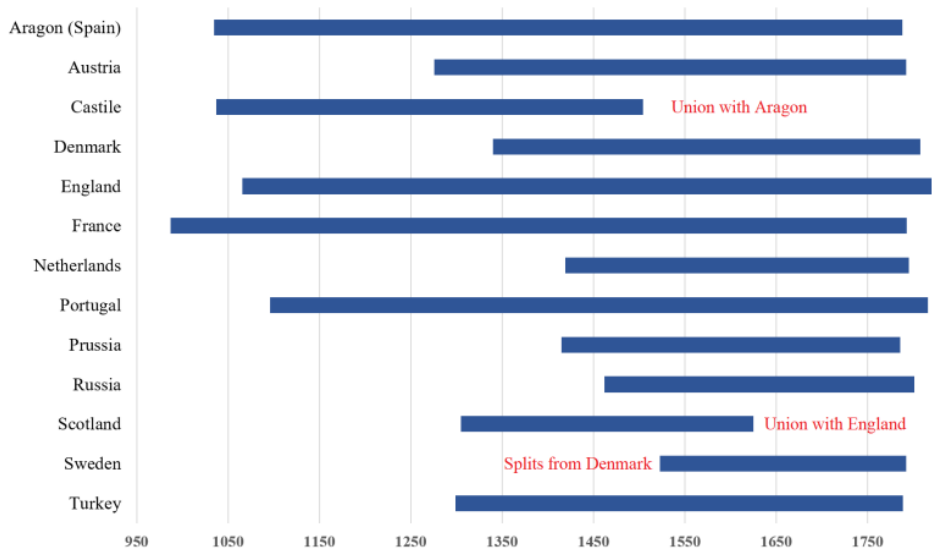
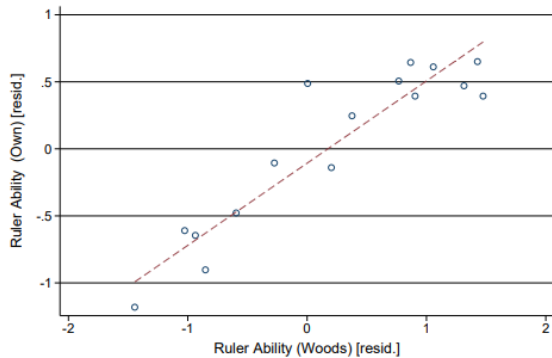


Figure A.1: Timeline of Sample Coverage: States in Sample

Is Woods' coding trustworthy?

- The obvious problem: the same man graded both the ruler and the state.
- The authors had research assistants re-code both variables from reference works, **without seeing Woods**.
- The independent gradings agree closely with Woods and with each other.
- The results hold using only the authors' own coding.

Ruler Ability (N=171)



State Performance (N=233)

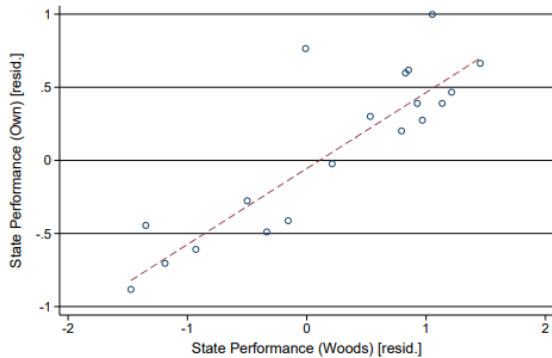
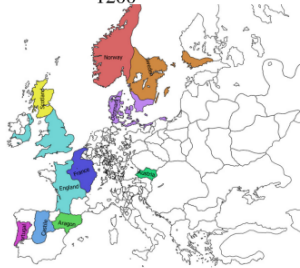


Figure A.2: Validation: Binscatters with state FE

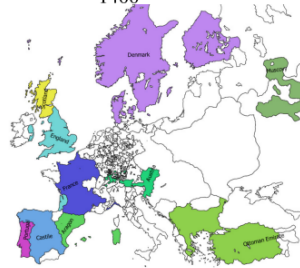
Two objective outcomes

- Since Woods' measure is a judgement, the paper adds two outcomes no historian graded.
- **Change in land area** during each reign, from European borders mapped at five-year intervals, 1100 to 1790.
- **Change in urban population** inside the (moving) borders, combining those maps with city population data.
- Cities matter: prestigious targets for ambitious rulers, and after the Commercial Revolution the place where taxable commerce sat.

1200



1400

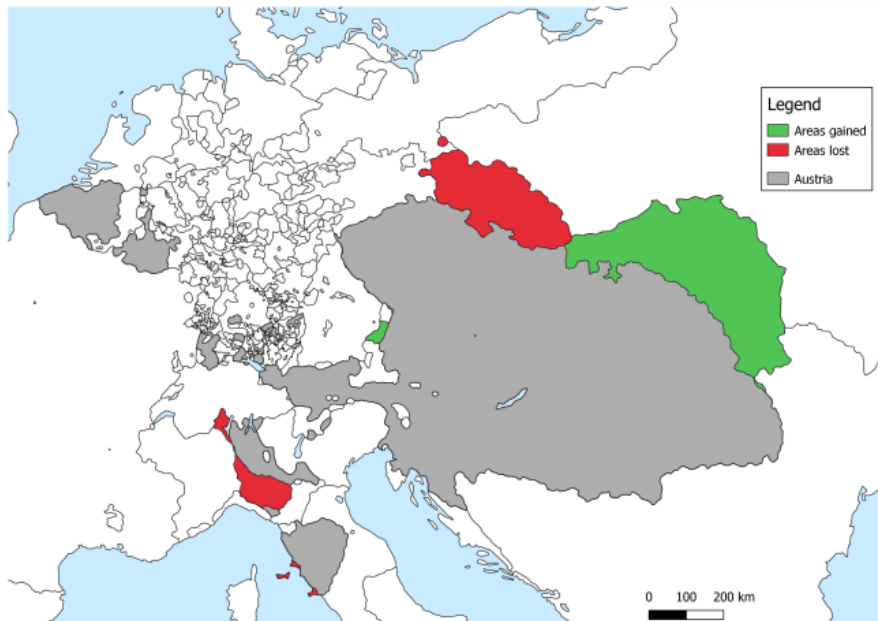


1600



1790



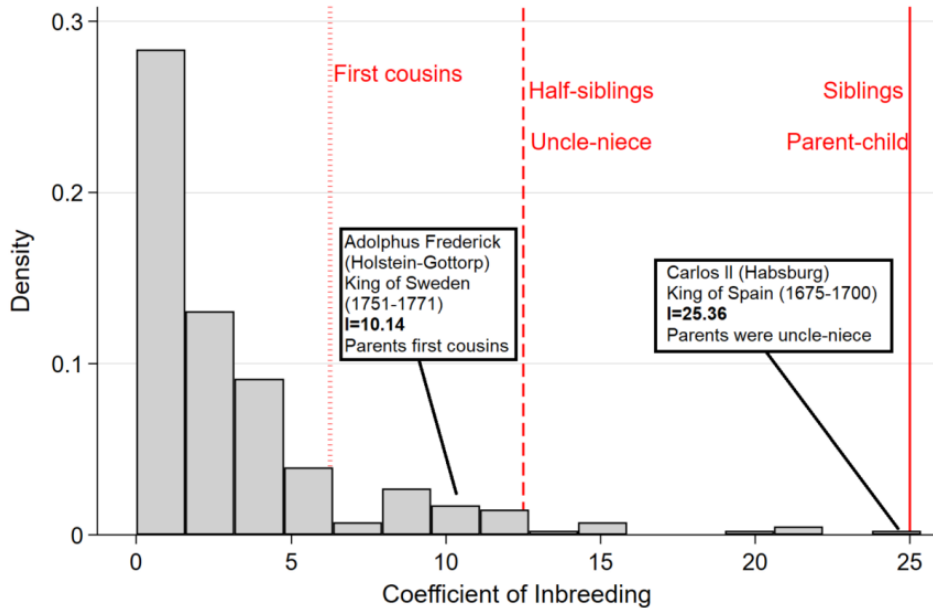


Reading the Austria map

- One reign, Maria Theresa's, 1740 to 1780.
- Red: Silesia lost to Prussia, plus losses in Italy.
- Green: areas gained from Poland.
- Net, Austria increased its area by **7%**. That single number is one observation in the data.

The coefficient of inbreeding

- The probability that both gene copies in an individual come from the same ancestor. Scale 0 to 100.
- Offspring of siblings or of a parent-child couple: 25. Uncle and niece: 12.5. First cousins: 6.25.
- Collected from roglo.eu, a crowd-sourced genealogy of European noble families, and cross-checked against published pedigrees.
- Available for 256 monarchs, of whom 238 also have Woods' assessments.

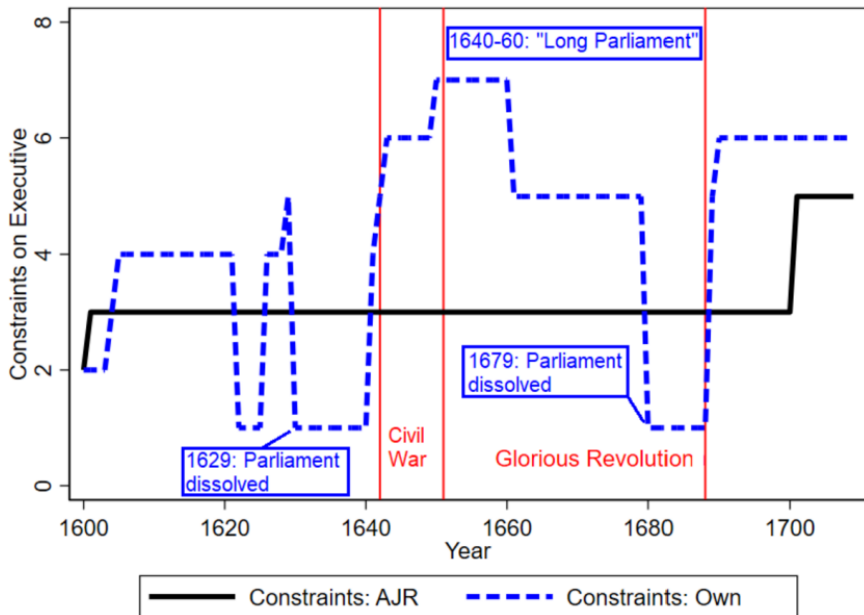


Reading the histogram

- Most monarchs sit near zero, but the right tail is long.
- Carlos II is the extreme point at 25.36, past the sibling line, with parents who were “merely” uncle and niece.
- Adolphus Frederick of Sweden, 1751 to 1771, is nearly at the uncle-niece level although his parents were only first cousins.
- Both gaps are the **hidden** inbreeding accumulated in earlier generations. This is what the couples marrying could not see.

Constraints on ruler power

- The authors also code, year by year, how far institutions limited each monarch, above all parliaments.
- They refine the Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson measure of constraints on the executive from centuries down to single years.
- A reign counts as **constrained** if constraints in the 5 to 10 years before it started were above “substantial limitations on executive authority”.
- Lagging it matters: institutions in place before a ruler arrives cannot be a response to that ruler.



Reading the England figure

- Solid line: one constant value for the whole 17th century. Dashed line: the authors' annual coding.
- 1629, parliament dissolved, Charles I “raising money by hand-to-mouth expedients, reviving old taxes and old feudal privileges of the crown”. The measure falls to “no regular limitations on the executive's actions”.
- 1640 to 1660, the Long Parliament, and the Triennial Act of 1641 “requiring the summoning of parliament every 3 years without an initiative of the crown”. The measure jumps.
- Another swing around the **Glorious Revolution**. This variation is what the last part of the paper uses.

Results

Ability and performance move together

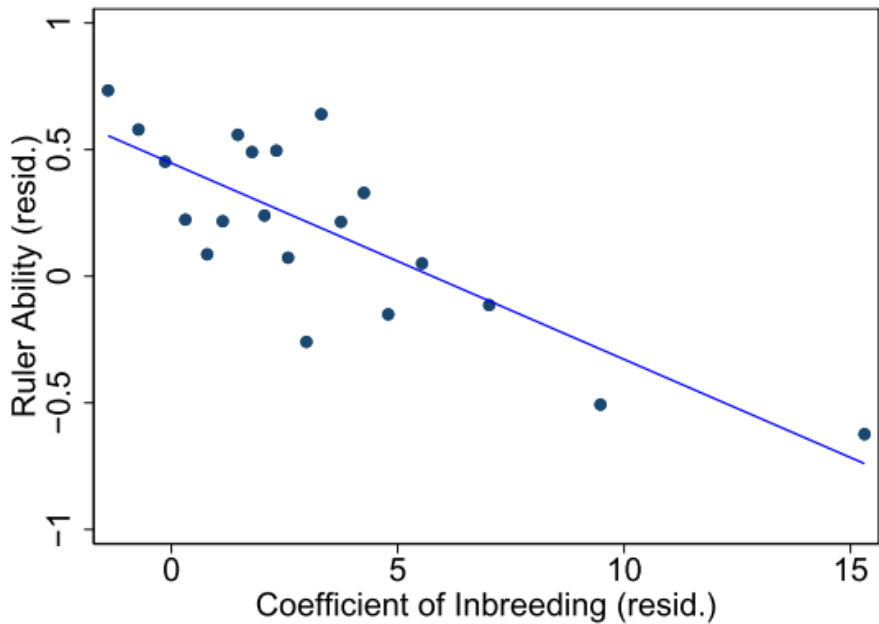
- Comparing rulers of the same state over time, more able rulers go with better states on all three measures.
- A one standard deviation step up in ruler ability (roughly one notch on Woods' scale): broad state performance up 0.62, land area up about 11%, urban population up about 10%.
- Woods had already computed this link in his raw data a century ago.
- But it is only an **association**.

Why that is not enough

- Omitted factors could drive both the state's fortunes and who sits on the throne.
- Reverse causality: a well-run state may select or produce more capable rulers.
- And historians may simply have graded the rulers of successful states more generously.
- Woods graded both variables, so this last worry is not hypothetical.

The natural experiment

- Two features combined.
- Hereditary succession put a predetermined person on the throne, whatever his ability.
- Inbreeding moved that person's ability, and the effect was **unknown** to everyone involved, families and historians alike.
- Much of it was hidden in the tangled family trees, invisible even to the couples marrying.
- Together: variation in ruler ability that is close to random.



More inbred rulers were less able rulers

- Each dot is a group of more than ten rulers, after taking out persistent differences between states.
- The line is clearly downward sloping, and it is not driven by the extreme cases.
- A one standard deviation rise in inbreeding lowers ruler ability by about **0.3** standard deviations.
- That is the same order of magnitude as the medical literature finds for first-cousin marriage.

Inbreeding and the state

- Going straight from inbreeding to outcomes, skipping ability: more inbred rulers had clearly worse states.
- One standard deviation more inbreeding: broad state performance down 0.25, land area down about **5%**, urban population down about 4%.
- Territory and urban population are objective on both sides of the comparison. No historian's judgement enters.
- So the finding is not an artifact of Woods' grading.

Ruler ability and the state

- Putting the two steps together gives the effect of ability itself.
- One standard deviation more ruler ability: broad state performance up about **0.8**, land area up about 16%, urban population up about 14%.
- Larger than the plain association, which fits Woods having favored rulers from old, heavily intermarried dynasties.
- For six states with annual income data, more able rulers raise per capita growth by about 0.2% a year, roughly the mean growth rate of the period.

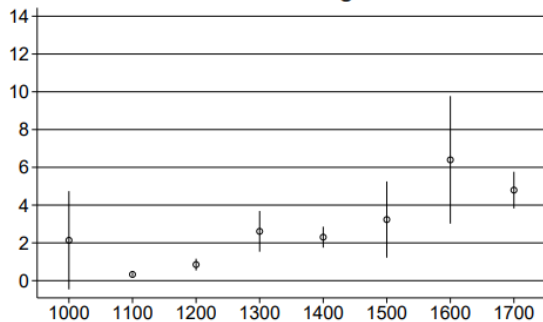
How big is that?

- Spain had heavily inbred rulers (average 9.71) and lost 7% of its European territory between 1500 and 1790.
- Prussia's rulers over the same period averaged 4.13.
- Swap the average Spanish ruler for the average Prussian one: Spanish area grows 3.9 percentage points per reign.
- Accumulated over the 12 reigns from 1500 to 1790, that is a territorial **gain of 58%** instead of a loss of 7%.
- Taken at face value, and worth arguing about.

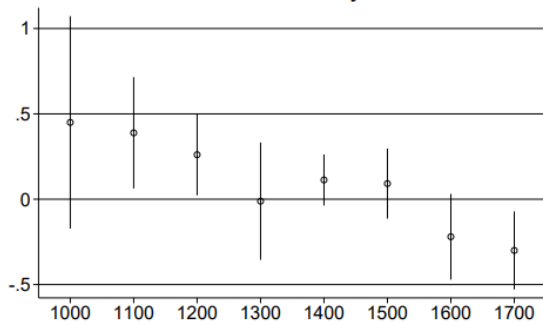
Which trait was doing the work?

- Inbreeding damages many things at once, so the authors test the alternatives.
- About **three quarters** of the effect runs through cognitive ability.
- A much smaller part runs through noncognitive ability, such as emotional stability.
- No evidence for physical channels: height, strength, longevity, number of offspring.

Inbreeding



Ruler Ability



Reading the trends

- Century by century, inbreeding among Europe's monarchs **rises**, sharply after 1500.
- Over the same centuries, average ruler ability falls.
- Consistent with the argument, but also a warning: both variables trend.
- The results survive controls for century and for state-specific time trends, and the pair comparisons later in the paper.

What would have to be true for this to fail

- The comparison is clean only if inbreeding touched the state **through the ruler's ability** and nothing else.
- The worrying story: families married kin precisely when the state was in trouble, trading health risk for dynastic advantage.
- Then the next ruler would be both more inbred and the heir to a state already in decline.
- Note the timing: inbreeding is fixed by marriages in the parents' generation or earlier, before the reign being measured.

Hidden inbreeding

- Split the coefficient in two.
- The **naive** part comes from the parents' own relationship: first cousins, uncle and niece.
- The **hidden** part comes from the tangled pedigree two, three or more generations back.
- The results hold using only the hidden part, and hold while controlling for the naive part.
- So an alternative story now has to be about marriage decisions at least two generations earlier, uncorrelated with the parents' own choice.

Other checks

- Past state performance predicts neither the next ruler's ability nor performance in his reign.
- Robust to controlling for conflict, to strategic marriage outside the kin network, and to the ruler's order within the dynasty.
- Robust to keeping only documented firstborn sons, to extending the sample to 1914, and to adding Hungary, Poland, Bohemia and Bavaria.
- A **placebo**: reshuffling inbreeding at random within each state almost never reproduces the result.

Comparing contemporaries

- Last precaution: compare rulers of **different** states who reigned at the same time, filtering out Europe-wide shocks such as the Black Death, the Reformation and long wars.
- There are 4152 such overlapping pairs, and inbreeding for both rulers in 2382 of them.
- Carlos III's Spain saw "continued improvement in financial and commercial conditions, including agriculture and the useful arts".
- His contemporary Louis XV, "weak, indolent", presided over the "disastrous Seven Years War" and a "decline in commerce", where "the peasantry were reduced to extreme misery".
- Their inbreeding gap: 3.9 against 9.55.

What able rulers did better

- Strongest effects on **law and order**, finances, administrative efficiency and diplomatic prestige.
- Also on agriculture, commerce and the general living conditions of the population.
- Urban population grew mostly by acquiring urbanized territory, not by cities growing inside existing borders.
- That last point is not a puzzle: strong rulers also kept cities' ambitions for independence in check.

War

- Less inbred, more capable rulers were **less** likely to be in conflict.
- Entirely driven by international conflict, not domestic.
- But when they did fight, their armies won a larger proportion of battles.
- Reading: they chose their wars, avoiding the risky ones, and expanded into valuable, densely populated territory.

Do institutions change this?

- Were states simply at the mercy of whoever was born next?
- Ruler ability mattered only where the ruler's power was **largely unconstrained**.
- Unconstrained ruler, one standard deviation more able: area up about 14%, urban population up about 16%.
- Constrained ruler, facing substantial limitations on his authority: the effect is slightly below zero and indistinguishable from nothing.
- England fits: monarchs mattered before 1600 and stop mattering after, as the Civil War and the Glorious Revolution bind the crown.

The implication the authors draw

- Parliaments strengthened in northwestern Europe from the 16th century on.
- Parliamentary meeting frequency above the 75th percentile, more than 0.5 meetings a year, neutralizes the ruler's effect entirely.
- Consanguinity among the dynasties was rising at the same time.
- So strong parliaments may have **shielded** those states from ever more inbred royal elites.

Takeaway: rulers and states

- First systematic causal evidence that European rulers mattered for their states, 10th to 18th century.
- Identification: succession fixed by birth, ability moved by inbreeding whose effects nobody knew.
- The channel is the ruler's **cognitive ability**, not his height, health or fertility.
- Rulers did make history, “shaping the European map during the period that laid the foundation for modern nation states”.
- And they did it only where nothing checked them.

Queens

Dube and Harish (2020), *Queens*

Queens

Oeindrila Dube

University of Chicago and National Bureau of Economic Research

S. P. Harish

William and Mary

Do states experience more peace under female leadership? We examine this question in the context of Europe over the fifteenth to twentieth centuries. We use gender of the firstborn and presence of a sister among previous monarchs as instruments for queenly rule. We find that polities led by queens engaged in war more than polities led by kings. While single queens were more likely to be attacked than single kings, married queens were more likely to attack than married kings. These results suggest asymmetries in the division of labor: married queens were more inclined to enlist their spouses in helping them rule, which enabled them ultimately to pursue more aggressive war policies.

The question

- Do states experience more peace under **female leadership**?
- One argument: women are less violent, and the recent peace among developed democracies has been credited to rising female leadership.
- The other: war policy is set with the whole state in mind, and an overly conciliatory stance weakens a state against its rivals.
- Same laboratory as before: European hereditary monarchies, here 1480 to 1913.

The difficulty

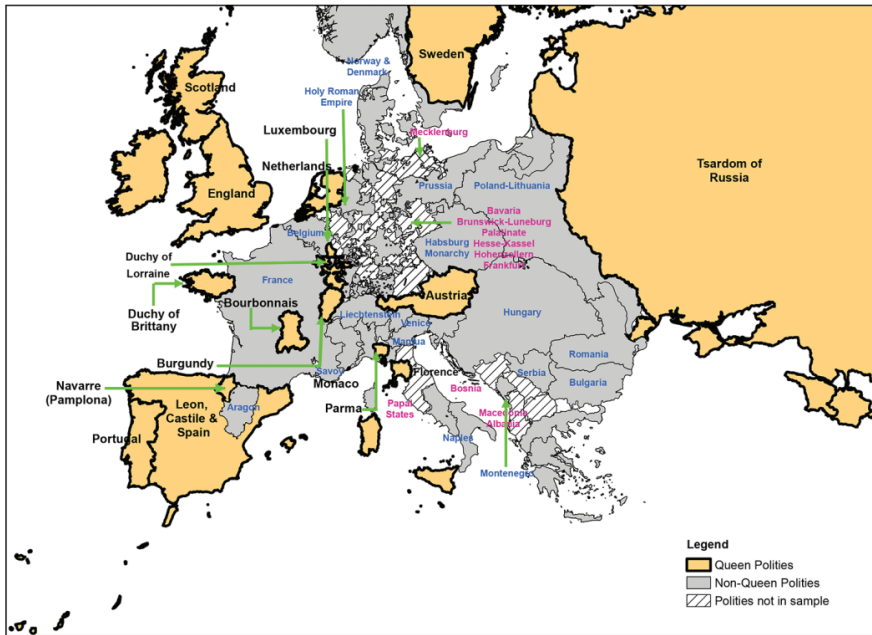
- Women may reach power disproportionately in times of peace, in elections and under hereditary rule alike.
- Then a plain comparison of queenly and kingly reigns tells you about the times, not about the ruler.
- The way around it is the mechanics of succession.
- Older **male** children of reigning monarchs were given priority.

How queens became queens

- Two accidents of family composition, unrelated to war, pushed a woman onto the throne.
- If the previous monarchs had a **firstborn male**, the chance of a queen falls by 17 to 24 percentage points.
- If the previous monarchs had a sister, a potential successor, the chance of a queen rises by about 29 percentage points.
- The gender of a firstborn is essentially a coin flip, which is why the authors lean on it.

The data

- A new panel tracking genealogy and war participation, year by year, 1480 to 1913.
- Morby (1989) for polities and reigns, Tompsett (1994) for genealogy, Wright (1942) for wars.
- Main sample: **18 polities** that ever had a queen, 193 reigns, of which 34 with a queen (18%), covering 29 distinct queens.
- In 24 of those reigns the queen ruled alone (in 14, married but still sole regent). In 10, she coruled with her spouse.



The war data

- Wright (1942) records when each participant enters and leaves each war.
- His threshold: hostilities “which were recognized as states of war in the legal sense or which involved over 50,000 troops”, plus smaller ones with legal consequences.
- By type: 77 balance-of-power wars, 8 defensive wars against the Ottoman Empire, 29 imperial and 40 civil.
- Average participation: a polity was at war in about **30%** of years.
- Wright also marks who initiated. The authors use his coding, not their own, to keep their hands off it.

Main result

- Polities led by queens engaged in war **more** than polities led by kings.
- In a given year, 38.8 percentage points more likely to be at war.
- Against a mean war participation of 29.6 percentage points, that is very large.
- The plain comparison gives only 11 to 13 points, consistent with queens arriving in calmer times.

Checks

- A firstborn son does not itself bring war in the reign in which he is born.
- Nor does it predict war in an **auxiliary sample** of 149 reigns across 18 polities that never had a queen.
- Queens do not inherit polities that were already more war-prone.
- Robust to controlling for the total number of siblings, and to dropping wars of succession.
- With few queens, the authors also show the result survives dropping any one queen, any two queens, or whole polities.

Two accounts

- **Perceived weakness**: queens seen as easy targets should show up more in wars where the polity *was attacked*.
- **Reign capacity**: queens who governed with more capacity should show up more in wars where the polity *attacked*, especially married queens.
- Two accounts, opposite predictions, both testable in the same data.

Perceived weakness

- Male monarchs were typically military commanders. For female monarchs the role stayed taboo, and the legitimacy of female rule was attacked on exactly that ground.
- John Knox on women, as Mary Tudor took the English throne: nature “doth paint them forth to be weak, frail, impatient, feeble, and foolish”.
- Frederick II of Prussia: “no woman should ever be allowed to govern anything”.
- A month after Maria Theresa acceded in Austria, he **invaded**.

Capacity through spouses

- War in this period demanded financing and management: permanent armies, professional soldiers, expensive fortification. English forces grew threefold between 1550 and 1780, Austrian forces 28-fold.
- Queens put their husbands in charge of armies and finances. Kings did not do the same with their wives.
- Monter: “female rulers needed male accessories for the same purpose, but for a long time they also needed them to command their armies” .
- The spouse was uniquely placed: he carried the legitimacy of the crown but, unlike a brother, usually could not **take** the throne.

Attacking or being attacked

- Splitting war participation by who started it.
- The whole queen effect comes from wars in which the polity **attacked**.
- Participation as the attacked side barely moves.
- Most of it is entry into new wars, not continuation of inherited ones.
- So perceived weakness on its own cannot account for the result.

By marital status

- Among **married** monarchs, queens attacked more than kings.
- Among **single** monarchs, queens were attacked more than kings.
- Marriage is not a random assignment here, so this split is suggestive rather than clean.
- Both accounts survive, applied to different women: single queens were read as weak, married queens had the capacity to attack.

Did it pay?

- Territorial change over a reign, from the Centennia Historical Atlas: loss, gain or no change.
- Queens were **less likely to lose** territory than kings.
- That comes both from gaining territory and from preserving it.
- Aggression was not obviously a mistake, at least on this measure.

Two queens who never married

- **Elizabeth I** of England, 1558 to 1602, described her coronation as her marriage to her kingdom. To her troops against the Armada: “I have the heart and Stomach of a King, and of a King of England too”.
- Her foreign policy is nonetheless read as cautious and largely defensive.
- **Christina** of Sweden, 1632 to 1653, argued to her own councilors that Sweden needed “a champion, who, when war threatened, could ride with his people to battle, while a woman could not”.
- She still oversaw military victories and sizable territorial gains in the Thirty Years' War.

Two queens who did marry

- **Isabel** of Leon and Castile, from 1474, married to Ferdinand of Aragon. He ran day-to-day policy in the War of Granada; she rode with the army in armor and kept the decision, and financed Columbus in 1492.
- **Maria Theresa** of Austria and Francis Stephen, who ran the centralization of administration and revenue that paid for her campaigns.
- They were said to rule “with a near seamless division of authority”.
- She achieved most of her military and political successes before his death, and withdrew afterwards.

Alternative accounts, tested

- **Signaling**: if queens fought to look strong, the effect should be largest early in a reign. It is not.
- **A male adviser**: if a foreign minister really set policy, the effect should be largest for monarchs who acceded young. It is not.
- So the authors read the effect as the queen's own.
- Note also where the effect is absent: reign length, regicide, and the survival of the polity.

One caveat the authors insist on

- The result is about the specific women whom a missing firstborn son or a well-placed aunt put on the throne.
- Under hereditary succession, the pool of eligible women is relatives of monarchs.
- A different pool, or different selectors, could give a different answer.
- Do not read this as a general claim about women and war.

Takeaway: queens

- Polities led by queens fought more, not less, than polities led by kings.
- Single queens were attacked more; married queens attacked more.
- “married queens had greater capacity to attack, based on a willingness to use their spouses to help them rule”.
- **Gender norms** shaped how queens could govern, and through that, war.

A Brazilian aside

- Brazil is the one hereditary monarchy in the Americas: the Braganças, 1822 to 1889.
- Dube and Harish's own example of the spouse mechanism is Maria II of Portugal, whose marriage contract of 1836 made her consort **chief of the army**.
- She was born in Rio, daughter of Pedro I of Brazil. Same dynasty, both sides of the Atlantic.
- Portugal is also one of Woods' 13 states, so the Braganças sit in both papers.
- Question to argue about: what constrained a Brazilian emperor, and would either paper predict that his ability mattered?

Putting the two together

- Both papers use the same accident: who rules is decided by birth, not by merit or by the state of the country.
- Ottinger and Voigtländer vary the ruler's **ability**; Dube and Harish vary the ruler's **gender**.
- Both find that the individual on the throne moved outcomes that we usually explain with geography, technology or class structure.
- And Ottinger and Voigtländer add the limit: that only held where nothing constrained the ruler.
- Which is an argument about institutions, not about kings.